Doctorate of Engineering
Master of Engineering

DENG614/MXX601: Engineering Practice and Key Research Methodologies

How to Choose a Research Topic

CHOOSING A RESEARCH TOPIC

Contents

- Picking up a topic
- Being flexible
- Searching for information
- Narrowing your topic
- Reading, reading, reading
- Begin writing

Pick a (manageable) Topic that Interests You

Try to pick a topic that you find interesting. This will ensure the research process is as engaging and fun as possible.

Ask yourself: What am I curious about? What questions do I have? What topic would I like to learn more about?

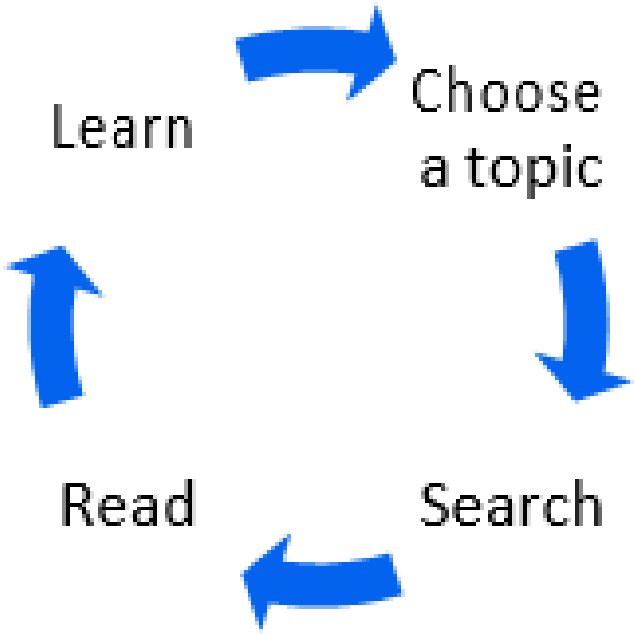
Also consider: How long does my research paper need to be? Choose a topic that seems appropriate for the length of the term/semester.

Get inspiration: From previously completed projects at EIT and from scientific journals.

Be Flexible

Understand that choosing a research topic is a **cyclical process**. No topic should be set in stone.

Be prepared to change your topic as you search for information, read about your topic, and learn more.



Search for Information on Your Topic

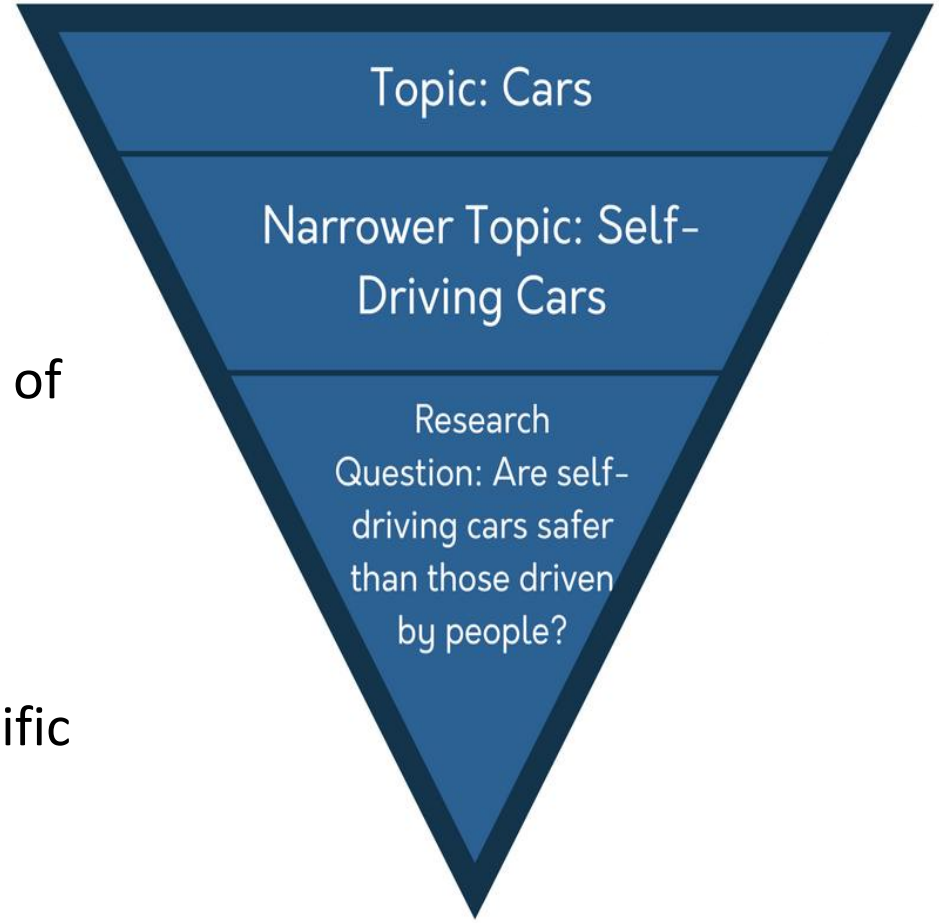
Search for information resources, such as scholarly articles and books, in the library catalogue and relevant databases. **What do you find?**

Search Results: 1 - 20 of 21,194

If you find too many information resources, your topic might be too broad. To make your topic more specific and narrow, try to zero in on a single aspect of your topic.

Some **questions** to ask yourself to help narrow your topic:

- Could you focus on a more specific region, time period, or group?
- Could you focus on a specific aspect of your topic?
- Can you narrow your topic to a specific problem or question?



Narrow your Topic and Search Again

Search Results: 1 - 2 of 2

- If you cannot find enough information resources, your topic might be too specific.
- To broaden your topic, consider removing some of your criteria from your research topic.

For example, instead of investigating the use of self-driven cars by Transperth in Western Australia, you might broaden your topic to the use of self-driven cars in Australia. Alternatively, you might need to adjust the keywords you have been using – talk to a librarian for help!

Read

about your topic

- As you read through your chosen information resources, you will learn more about your topic.
- In response to what you learn, you may wish to tweak your topic further.

Don’t be afraid to change your topic to reflect what you read.

Begin Writing

Research Proposal Writing

- Even while you're writing, your topic may change slightly.
- In many ways, writing is a way of thinking through your topic.

As you write—and think—you may decide to refine your topic to better reflect the content of your research paper.

Feels like a Never-ending Story?

Don’t worry. Keep in mind that **the heart of your topic is still your initial idea.**

The tweaking and refining that occurs throughout the research process is simply a way of ensuring your topic is manageable and accurately reflects the findings of your research.